UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Literary Criticism

Invitational A • 2020



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • Invitational A • 2020

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The genre of novel dominated by social customs, conventions, and habits of a particular social class, including the novels of Jane Austen, which is always characterized by realism and at times by satire, is the

   A) novel of character.
   B) novel of incident.
   C) novel of manners.
   D) novel of sensibility.
   E) novel of the soil.

2. The use of the morbid and the absurd for darkly comic purposes by such modern writers as Günter Grass, Thomas Pynchon, Kurt Vonnegut, Harold Pinter, and Edward Albee is known as

   A) black humor.
   B) blood and thunder.
   C) fantasy.
   D) surrealism.
   E) travesty.

3. The character directly opposed to the chief character of a literary work is called the

   A) agroikos.
   B) antagonist.
   C) braggadocio.
   D) eiron.
   E) protagonist.

4. The nineteenth-century British author of *Great Expectations*, *David Copperfield*, *Bleak House*, *Oliver Twist*, *Hard Times*, and *A Christmas Carol* is

   A) Charles Dickens.
   B) George Eliot.
   C) Thomas Hardy.
   D) Rudyard Kipling.
   E) William Makepeace Thackeray.

5. The continuation of the sense and grammatical construction of a line of verse from one stanza to the next stanza is called (a)

   A) chiasmus.
   B) enjambment.
   C) fused rhyme.
   D) run-on line.
   E) tagline.

6. A term applied in general to things English and in particular to the English royal court during the second quarter of the seventeenth century, a general term that can encompass both Cavalier and Puritan literary expression is

   A) Augustine.
   B) Caroline.
   C) Edwardian.
   D) Jacobean.
   E) Victorian.

7. The figure of speech that seeks, by tapping into the knowledge and memory of the reader, to secure a resonant emotional effect from the associations already existing in the reader's mind is

   A) allusion.
   B) influence.
   C) milieu.
   D) mimesis.
   E) résumé.

8. The recipient of the 1973 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for *The Optimist's Daughter* is

   A) Eudora Welty.
   B) Edith Wharton.
   C) Colson Whitehead.
   D) Thornton Wilder.
   E) Margaret Wilson.

9. **Not** among the many celebrated North American women writers known for their twentieth-century poetry is

   A) Maya Angelou.
   B) Margaret Atwood.
   C) Elizabeth Bishop.
   D) H. D.
   E) Emily Dickinson.

10. The literary trope that can be used to heighten effect, including humorous effect, through exaggeration is

    A) animism.
    B) gigantism.
    C) hyperbole.
    D) litotes.
    E) understatement.

11. **Not** to be found among a group of authors who might have gathered to discuss the extent to which James Joyce influenced twentieth-century literature is

A) Charles Dickens.
B) Graham Greene.
C) Doris Lessing.
D) Salman Rushdie.
E) Muriel Spark.

12. A figurative phrase used in Old Germanic languages as a synonym for a simple noun is known as (a)

A) caesura.
B) conceit.
C) euphemism.
D) kenning.
E) syllepsis.

13. The prose fiction genre that places unusual emphasis on interior characterization and on the motives, circumstances, and internal action that spring from and develop external action is the

A) campus novel.
B) epistolary novel.
C) picaresque novel.
D) psychological novel.
E) sociological novel.

14. The term that is widely used to refer to a "second self" created by an author and through whom, in the case of prose, the narrative is told is

A) allonym.
B) eponym.
C) persona.
D) pseudonym.
E) putative author.

15. The group of American writers born around 1900 who served in the First World War (many afterward spent time in Paris) and reacted during the 1920s against certain tendencies of older writers of their time is known as the

A) Beat Generation.
B) Black Mountain School.
C) Knickerbocker Group.
D) Lost Generation.
E) New York School.

16. The simple element that serves as a basis for expanded narrative; or, less strictly, a conventional situation, device, interest, or incident, often recurring, especially in art and music, is (a/n)

A) emblem.
B) motif.
C) objective correlative.
D) theme.
E) thesis.

17. The poetic foot consisting of an accented and an unaccented syllable, as in the word *happy*, is the

A) anapest.
B) dactyl.
C) pyrrhic.
D) spondee.
E) trochee.

18. The period in English Literature spanning the years 1660-1798 and including the Restoration Age, the Augustan Age, and the Age of Johnson is known as the

A) Contemporary Period.
B) Modernist Period.
C) Neoclassic Period.
D) Realistic Period.
E) Romantic Period.

19. The recipient of 2016 Nobel Prize for Literature "for having created new poetic expressions within the great American song tradition" is

A) Bob Dylan.
B) Arlo Guthrie.
C) Woody Guthrie.
D) Phil Ochs.
E) Pete Seeger.

20. A form of Japanese poetry, usually addressing either nature or one of its elements, that states—in three lines of five, seven, and five syllables—a clear picture designed to arouse a distinct emotion and suggest a specific spiritual insight, is (the)

A) haiku.
B) kabuki.
C) kitsch.
D) senryu.
E) tanka.

21. Rhyme in which the rhyming stressed syllables are followed by an undifferentiated identical unstressed syllable, such as *waken* and *forsaken* is

A) broken rhyme.
B) compound rhyme.
C) eye rhyme.
D) feminine rhyme.
E) masculine rhyme.

22. Poet of New England rural life and recipient of the Pulitzer Prize for Poetry in 1931, 1937, and 1943 is

A) W. H. Auden.
B) Robert Frost.
C) Forrest Gander.
D) Anthony Hecht.
E) Robert Penn Warren.

23. A term used, often narrowly, to suggest a certain complacency, hypocrisy, or squeamishness assumed to characterize the attitudes of the last half of the nineteenth century in Britain, all of which are apparent in the cautious manner with which writers treat such matters as profanity and sex, is

A) comstockery.
B) hedonism.
C) meliorism.
D) Puritanism.
E) Victorian.

24. **Not** among the many works of the twentieth-century American playwright and character-of-strength-in-the-face-of-McCarthyism Arthur Miller is

A) *The Crucible.*
B) *Death of a Salesman.*
C) *The Glass Menagerie.*
D) *The Misfits.*
E) *A View from the Bridge.*

25. The form of light verse that follows a definite pattern: five anapestic lines of which the first, second, and fifth, consisting of three feet, rhyme; and the third and fourth lines, consisting of two feet, rhyme, is the

A) clerihew.
B) dizain.
C) haiku.
D) limerick.
E) virelay.

26. The term coined by E. M. Forster for a character sufficiently complex to be able to surprise the reader without losing credibility is

A) dynamic character.
B) flat character.
C) round character.
D) static character.
E) stock character.

27. The Japanese filmic cartoon genre characterized by extreme stylization and asymmetrical design is

A) anime.
B) haiku.
C) kabuki.
D) manga.
E) senryu.

28. Authors, including James Fenimore Cooper, Bret Harte, Mark Twain, Horace Greeley, Hamlin Garland, Larry McMurtry, and Cormic McCarthy, whose writings address life in the United States during westward expansion are contributors to the genre known as

A) Frontier Literature.
B) Local Color Writing.
C) metafiction.
D) Native American Literature.
E) Popular Literature.

29. The playwright whose achievements include a Spanish-language production of *West Side Story* and earning the 2016 Pulitzer Prize for Drama for *Hamilton* is

A) Nilo Cruz.
B) Charles Fuller.
C) Donald Margulies.
D) Lin-Manuel Miranda.
E) Lynn Nottage.

30. A chronicle, usually autobiographical, presenting the life story of a rascal of low degree engaged in menial tasks and making his living more through his wit than his industry, and tending to be episodic and structureless, is known as a(n)

A) epistolary novel.
B) novel of character.
C) novel of manners.
D) novel of the soil.
E) picaresque novel.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with William Shakespeare's *The Tragedy of Othello: The Moor of Venice.*
Items 37-42 are associated with Kurt Vonnegut, Jr.'s *Player Piano*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Percy Bysshe Shelley's poetry (selected).

31. In Shakespeare's *Tragedy of Othello*, the caustic observation, "A fellow [. . .] / That never set a squadron in the field, / [. . .]: Mere prattle without practice / Is all his soldiership," is Iago's estimation of

A) Brabantio.
B) Cassio.
C) Gratiano.
D) Othello.
E) Roderigo.

32. Alternately calling it first "an idle and most false imposition" and later "the immediate jewel of [the] soul," Iago references a person's

A) marital status.
B) military rank.
C) reputation.
D) role in an Elizabethan tragedy.
E) social status.

33. Roderigo's confession, "I have no devotion to the deed, / And yet he hath given me satisfying reasons," is the rational for his attempting to kill

A) Cassio.
B) Gratiano.
C) Lodovico.
D) Montano.
E) Othello.

34. The first character to realize—characteristically late—that Iago's "words and performances are no kin together" is

A) Cassio.
B) Desdemona.
C) Emilia.
D) Othello.
E) Roderigo.

35. Iago wants revenge on Othello because "it is thought abroad that [Othello] has done [Iago's] office"; this *office* is

A) adviser to the Duke.
B) captain.
C) flag-bearer.
D) lieutenant.
E) sleeping with Emilia.

36. The honourable Lieutenant Cassio, recognizing his own character flaw, voices his sincere wish that "courtesy would invent some other custom of entertainment" than

A) dancing.
B) drinking wine.
C) reading closet dramas.
D) singing.
E) swordplay.

37. In Kurt Vonnegut Jr.'s fantasy *Player Piano* Paul Proteus asks Bud Calhoun to design, for Proteus's cat, Kitty, a(n)

A) automatic pet door.
B) catnip dispenser.
C) food dispenser.
D) mouse alarm.
E) radio collar.

38. "[A]ny man who cannot support himself by doing a job better than a machine is employed by the government, either in the Army or the

A) Reassessment and Reclamation Corps."
B) Recasting and Reservicing Corps."
C) Reconstruction and Reclamation Corps."
D) Rehabilitation and Renewal Service."
E) Restoration and Wrecker Service."

39. In the country club's game room, Fred Berringer, the barely competent young engineer from Minnesota, introduces Paul Proteus to

A) Checker Charley.
B) Edgar Hagstrohm.
C) Ewing Halyard.
D) Jonathan Lynn.
E) the Shah of Bratpuhr.

40. The allusory admonition featuring Thoreau's asking Emerson, "Why aren't you here [in jail with me]?" is offered to

A) Baer by Kroner.
B) Kroner by Baer.
C) Pond by Haycox.
D) Proteus by Finnerty.
E) Proteus by Haycox.

41. The director of physical education at Cornell University whose interest in Buck Young does not include Young's potential as an engineer is

A) Dr. Dodge.
B) Dr. Garth.
C) Dr. Pond.
D) Dr. Roseberry.
E) Dr. Shepherd.

42. The radical group of rebels and saboteurs led by Reverend James Lasher whose mission is to destroy machines and to undermine the Organization is known as the

A) Dead Poets Society.
B) Ghost Shirt Society.
C) Homestead Freedom Society.
D) Homestead Hooligan Society.
E) Lasher Patriot Society.

Items 43-46 refer to Percy Bysshe Shelley's

Ozymandias

I met a traveller from an antique land,
Who said—"Two vast and trunkless legs of stone
Stand in the desert. . . . Near them, on the sand,
Half sunk a shattered visage lies, whose frown,
And wrinkled lip, and sneer of cold command,
Tell that its sculptor well those passions read
Which yet survive, stamped on these lifeless things,
The hand that mocked them, and the heart that fed;
And on the pedestal, these words appear:
My name is Ozymandias, King of Kings;
Look on my Works, ye Mighty, and despair!
Nothing beside remains. Round the decay
Of that colossal Wreck, boundless and bare
The lone and level sands stretch far away."

43. The reordering of the normal order of sentence elements in line 6 of Percy Bysshe Shelley's "Ozymandias" in order to accommodate the "needs" of the line's rhyme and rhythm is known as

A) abridgment.
B) accentualism.
C) inversion.
D) ornamentalism.
E) reversal.

44. The repetition of sibilant sounds not only at the beginning of syllables but across the syllables of line 4 of the sonnet is an example of

A) assonance.
B) consonance.
C) dissonance.
D) resonance.
E) sigmatism.

45. The thematic concern that Shelley's sonnet presents might easily be summed up in the admonitory observation

A) antiques are not a good investment.
B) inscriptions last longer than visages.
C) Ozymandias's Wrecks predate Vonnegut's.
D) power is fleeting.
E) stone carvings do not last forever.

46. Lines 4 through 8 reflect the persona's

A) ability to read ancient carvings.
B) inability to rhyme every other line.
C) interest in ruined artifacts.
D) recognition of the sculptor's skill.
E) revisiting lifeless things as a hobby.

Items 47-50 refer to Percy Bysshe Shelley's

Song: To the Men of England

Men of England, wherefore plough
For the lords who lay ye low?
Wherefore weave with toil and care
The rich robes your tyrants wear?

Wherefore feed and clothe and save
From the cradle to the grave
Those ungrateful drones who would
Drain your sweat—nay, drink your blood?

Wherefore, Bees of England, forge
Many a weapon, chain, and scourge,
That these stingless drones may spoil
The forced produce of your toil?

Have ye leisure, comfort, calm,
Shelter, food, love's gentle balm?
Or what is it ye buy so dear
With your pain and with your fear?

Sow seed—but let no tyrant reap:
Find wealth—let no imposter heap:

Shelley continued

Weave robes—let not the idle wear:
Forge arms—in your defence to bear.

Shrink to your cellars, holes, and cells—
In hall ye deck another dwells.
Why shake the chains ye wrought? Ye see
The steel ye tempered glance on ye.

With plough and spade and hoe and loom
Trace your grave and build your tomb
And weave your winding-sheet—till fair
England be your Sepulchre.

47. In Percy Bysshe Shelley's "Song: To the Men of England," the speaker's addressing an audience from whom he apparently, especially in light of the final two stanzas' tone, does not expect an answer is an example of

A) apostrophe.
B) aside.
C) harangue.
D) invocation.
E) soliloquy.

48. The return in the third stanza to the hive imagery established in the second stanza ("Those ungrateful drones") in which the speaker addresses the "Bees of England" is an example, focused though it is, of a(n)

A) aphorism.
B) controlling image.
C) dead metaphor.
D) diminishing metaphor.
E) epigram.

49. The use of more conjunctions than is normal as found in line 25's "plough and spade and hoe and loom" is an example of

A) asyndeton.
B) conjunctivitis.
C) interpolation.
D) polysyndeton.
E) polyptoton.

50. The word *wherefore*, as the speaker uses it throughout the first three stanzas of Shelley's "To the Men of England," means

A) 'what.'
B) 'whatever.'
C) 'when.'
D) 'where.'
E) 'why.'

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism

Items 51-54 refer to William Shakespeare's

Sonnet 73

That time of year thou mayst in me behold
When yellow leaves, or none, or few, do hang
Upon those boughs which shake against the cold,
Bare ruined choirs, where late the sweet birds sang.
In me thou see'st the twilight of such day
As after sunset fadeth in the west
Which by and by black night doth take away,
Death's second self, that seals up all in rest.
In me thou see'st the glowing of such fire,
That on the ashes of his youth doth lie,
As the death-bed, whereon it must expire,
Consum'd with that which it was nourish'd by.
This thou perceiv'st, which makes thy love more strong,
To love that well, which thou must leave ere long.

51. In referencing this particular time in his life, the persona in William Shakespeare's "[That time of year thou mayest in me behold]" relies on

A) blank verse.
B) chiaroscuro.
C) quibbles.
D) rhyme.
E) visual imagery.

52. The line in the persona's argument in which the appearance of a strong paradox reinforces the sonnet's theme is

A) line 2.
B) line 5.
C) line 8.
D) line 10.
E) line 12.

53. Shakespeare's attention to the poem's metrical iambic pentameter is obvious in line 13, a line in which the poet relies on

A) elision.
B) epenthesis.
C) metathesis.
D) paragoge.
E) prothesis.

54. The persona's metaphorical "Death's second self" in line 8 is

A) a ghost.
B) night.
C) sleep.
D) a spirit.
E) the twilight.

Items 55-57 refer to Alanis Morissette's

Head over Feet

I had no choice but to hear you
You stated your case time and again
I thought about it

You treat me like I'm a princess
I'm not used to liking that
You ask how my day was

You've already won me over in spite of me
And don't be alarmed if I fall head over feet
Don't be surprised if I love you for all that you are
I couldn't help it
It's all your fault

Your love is thick and it swallowed me whole
You're so much braver than I gave you credit for
That's not lip service

You've already won me over in spite of me
And don't be alarmed if I fall head over feet
Don't be surprised if I love you for all that you are
I couldn't help it
It's all your fault

You are the bearer of unconditional things
You held your breath and the door for me
Thanks for your patience

You're the best listener that I've ever met
You're my best friend
Best friend with benefits
What took me so long

I've never felt this healthy before
I've never wanted something rational
I am aware now
I am aware now

You've already won me over in spite of me
And don't be alarmed if I fall head over feet
Don't be surprised if I love you for all that you are
I couldn't help it
It's all your fault

55. The phrase "head over feet," which serves as both title for and central image in Morissette's lyric, is a

A) *carmen figuratum.*
B) gest.
C) metaphor.
D) simile.
E) tautology.

56. The figure of speech in which one word is placed in the same grammatical relationship to two words but in quite different senses, as *held* is linked in different senses to *breath* and to *door* in "You held your breath and the door for me" (line 21), is

A) analepsis.
B) catalexis.
C) eclipsis.
D) ellipsis.
E) syllepsis.

57. The combining of figures of speech with such extreme compression that the literal sense of the statement is eclipsed or reduced to anomaly or nonsense, as occurs in "Your love is thick and it swallowed me whole" (line 12), is an example of

A) dualism.
B) imagery.
C) metalepsis.
D) reification.
E) rhetoric.

Items 58-59 refer to Mary Holtby's

Milk-cart

Slow sleet, still street; far beat huge feet;
Clip-clop, start-stop, ear-flop, turd-drop;
Pint-take, gate-shake, sleep-break, house-wake;
Short-stay; stamp, neigh; on way—new day.

58. The rhyme that dominates Holtby's poem is

A) beginning rhyme.
B) compound rhyme.
C) feminine rhyme.
D) identical rhyme.
E) leonine rhyme.

59. An interesting aspect of Mary Holtby's "Milk-cart" is her combining of the onomatopoeic with the metrical

A) dactyls.
B) iambs.
C) pyrrhics.
D) spondees.
E) trochees.

Items 60-65 refer to Emily Dickinson's

[A Bird came down the Walk]

A Bird came down the Walk—
He did not know I saw—
He bit an Angleworm in halves
And ate the fellow, raw,

And then he drank a Dew
From a convenient Grass—
And then hopped sidewise to the Wall
To let a Beetle pass—

He glanced with rapid eyes
That hurried all around—
They looked like frightened Beads, I thought—
He stirred his Velvet Head

Like one in danger, Cautious,
I offered him a Crumb,
And he unrolled his feathers
And rowed him softer home—

Than Oars divide the Ocean,
Too silver for a seam—
Or Butterflies, off Banks of Noon
Leap, plashless, as they swim.

60. Emily Dickinson's narrative lyric depends on the repeated use of the

A) apostrophe.
B) hyperbole.
C) metaphor.
D) pun.
E) simile.

61. The overriding metrical pattern of Dickinson's poem is

A) iambic tetrameter.
B) iambic trimeter.
C) trochaic pentameter.
D) trochaic tetramter.
E) trochaic trimeter.

62. Line 20's *plashless* is an example of

A) internal rhyme.
B) onomatopoeia.
C) *rime riche*.
D) solecism.
E) tautology.

63. The poem's subtle auditory imagery occurs in the

A) first and third stanzas.
B) fourth and fifth stanzas.
C) second stanza.
D) third stanza.
E) third and fourth stanzas.

64. Thematically, the poem reflects on a

A) girl's attempt to feed a bird.
B) hunter's recognition that birds are predatory.
C) naturalist's appreciating a bird's remaining wild.
D) poet's gift for alliteration.
E) woman's squeamishness regarding wild things.

65. Line 19's "Banks of Noon" is a

A) conceit.
B) metaphor.
C) paradox.
D) simile.
E) tautology.

The required Tie-Breaking Essay prompt is found on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read the nineteenth-century English romantic Percy Bysshe Shelley's "Ozymandias" and the medieval Persian poet Sheikh Sa'di's [A Vision of the Sultan Mahmud] and offer an analytical discussion of the shared theme.

Ozymandias

I met a traveller from an antique land
Who said:—Two vast and trunkless legs of stone
Stand in the desert. Near them on the sand,
Half sunk, a shatter'd visage lies, whose frown
And wrinkled lip and sneer of cold command
Tell that its sculptor well those passions read
Which yet survive, stamp'd on these lifeless things,
The hand that mock'd them and the heart that fed.
And on the pedestal these words appear:
"My name is Ozymandias, king of kings:
Look on my works, ye mighty, and despair!"
Nothing beside remains: round the decay
Of that colossal wreck, boundless and bare,
The lone and level sands stretch far away.

Percy Bysshe Shelley
1817

[**A Vision of Sultan Mahmud**]

Many famous men have been buried under ground
Of whose existence on earth not a trace has remained
And that old corpse which had been surrendered to the earth
Was so consumed by the soil that not a bone remains.
The glorious name of Nushirvan survives in good repute
Although much time elapsed since he passed away.
Do good, O man, and consider life as a good fortune,
The more so, as when a shout is raised, a man exists no more.

Sheikh Sa'di
1258
trans. Edward Rehatsek

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE THIS KEY TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST.

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Invitational A • 2020

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1.	C	330
2.	A	58
3.	B	30
4.	A	560
5.	B	174
6.	B	75
7.	A	14
8.	A	603
9.	E	567
10.	C	242
11.	A	564
12.	D	266
13.	D	388
14.	C	361
15.	D	279
16.	B	309
17.	E	486
18.	C	320
19.	A	
20.	A	225
21.	D	196
22.	B	604
23.	E	496
24.	C	581
25.	D	272
26.	C	425
27.	A	29
28.	A	211
29.	D	
30.	E	362
31.	B	1.1.22
32.	C	2.3.287
33.	A	5.1.9
34.	E	4.2.213
35.	E	1.3.430
36.	B	2.3.35
37.	D	4
38.	C	21
39.	A	55
40.	D	143
41.	D	271
42.	B	226
43.	C	257
44.	E	
45.	D	
46.	D	
47.	A	37
48.	B	108
49.	D	373
50.	E	
51.	E	
52.	E	
53.	A	167
54.	C	
55.	C	294
56.	E	466
57.	C	294
58.	E	312
59.	D	452
60.	E	[11,13,17]
61.	B	
62.	B	337
63.	B	
64.	C	
65.	B	294

FOLD along the **three** longitudinal lines for ease in grading. ➔

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties. ***Simply adjust ranking***.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

DO NOT mark (cross out) actual **LETTER** answer; mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

Page numbers refer to the *Handbook* 12e, the Folger's updated *Othello*, the Dial Press *Player Piano*, and Oxford World's Classics P. B. Shelley collection.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Shelley's "Ozymandias" and Sa'di's [A Vision of Sultan Mahmud]

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

diction (word choice),
imagery,
irony,
simile,
tone (word choice),
explicit moral statement (Sa'di), and
implicit moral statement (Shelley).

The prompt asks the contestant to address the poems' common theme, which involves a recognition that the power as well as the glory (empire in the case of Ozymandias; reputation in the case of Nushirvan) acquired during a person's time on earth are indeed as fleeting as any material goods.

The contestant's approach might be a simplistic comparison of the poems as vehicles to carry the theme, or the approach might recognize the difference between a Western traveler's physical journey to a point where the past speaks to the present (coincidentally, a geographic point in the East) and in the case of Mahmud's vision, a journey that is not actually physical but does involve specific imagery of the physical body's "surrender to the earth"—the past, in Mahmud's vision being less remote and the geography more immediate.

Additionally, a more sophisticated contrast (though generalized) might be drawn between the Westerner's need for an empirical, perhaps literal, vehicle for the transitory nature of man's endeavors (what we build falls down) and the Easterner's appreciation of the parable—the less literal (a dream vision sufficing).

Optimism pervades both poems' messages: Shelley's is couched in the irony that feared strength suffers demise even though it speaks the strength of endurance ("Look on my works, ye mighty, and despair"), and Sa'di's optimism is proffered as a *raison d'être*: live a good life ("Do good, O man, and consider life as a good fortune").